I’m Happy (Hope You’re Happy Too)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/56524018.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Tung Lashor, Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra), Peekablue (She-Ra), Flutterina (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - 1990s, Alternate Universe - Wrestling, Professional Wrestling - Freeform, Drug Use, Cocaine, Steroids, Violence, Sexual Tension, Human Catra (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Implied Sexual Content, Swearing, And Lots of It, SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra), Injury, Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Fluff, Everyone is a professional wrestler, Everyone is on cocaine

Language:
English

Collections:
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Stats:
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I’m Happy (Hope You’re Happy Too)

by Kurt_Angles_Tailbone

Summary

Catra knew damn well that if she kissed Adora now, like every part of her that wasn’t her brain was urging her to, they would never make it out of the stall in time. They might not even catch their flight back to America.

So Catra brushed the lingering white dust off Adora’s nostrils, and slapped her.

It is the summer of 1995, and Etherian Elite Wrestling is hosting the Bash at the Beach pay-per-view at Huntington Beach, California. Adora is the company’s top star, and yet she feels helpless as she watches Catra go down a one-way street of self-destruction inside the ring. Meanwhile, Mermista struggles to make something of her career as a singles performer.

(She-Ra Professional Wrestling AU)

Notes

Done for the Summer SPOPtacular prompt: Beach Episode!

Professional wrestling, in short, is a scripted sport, the performance of which relies on a great deal of athleticism, choreographed but very real physicality, lots of pageantry and soap opera storytelling.

See the end of the work for more notes

- Inspired by Like A Heartbeat, Drives You Mad by PointlesslyPoetic

Pale Shadow of a Woman

Chapter Notes

Translations are at the end of the chapter. Below follows a glossary for wrestling lingo that will appear in this chapter:

Kayfabe: The presentation of professional wrestling as being entirely legitimate or unscripted, and staying in-character.

Work: Anything planned to happen, or to 'deceive' an audience into believing what is happening on-screen to be real. Also used in saying someone is getting **worked**, meaning they are being fooled.

Gassed up: Feeling the effects of steroids, worked up.

Promo: An in-character interview or speech done by wrestlers to move a storyline forward, generate interest or promote a match.

Valet: A person who accompanies wrestlers to the ring as a sidekick. Generally not involved in the actual match unless they interfere.

Card: The matches planned for a wrestling event. **Midcard** and **midcarders** refer to matches and wrestlers considered less prestigious than the main event.

Championships: Championships are referred to as a **championship**, **title**, **belt** or **strap** interchangeably, as they are represented by a belt.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Rock and wrestling," you'll mumble under your breath. "I should've been a part of that."

- Diamond Dallas Page

"…these past months have been hard on me and I'm quite confused—physically, mentally and emotionally drained. I feel like a wounded animal stuck with spears, staggering around aimlessly… I keep going on like there is nothing wrong. Sooner or later I will break. I want to break, to let it go in an agonizing wail—but I just can't seem to let it out."

- Bret 'The Hitman' Hart

July 7th, 1995

Aschaffenburg, Germany

Unterfrankenhalle

Catra

"Do YOU… Scorpia… think that you've got… what it TAKES? DO YOU… Scorpia, think that you can best… the unbested? You do not possess… the strength… that I posses. You do not possess the POWER… that was bestowed upon me by my family's lineage. The power of Grayskull… and now… Scorpia… the HONOUR of Grayskull… and you don't have… the power that—the power that I… I—FUCK!"

"Cut!"

Adora waved her hand frustratedly, casting a whole spray of sweat at the camera crew. "No, don't cut, I've got it, I've got it."

"Alright—"

"Come on, don't cut."

"Alright just… run it back. Remember, 'Scorpia, you do not possess'—"

"I know!" Adora flared, running a hand through her wet hair. "That's what I've been saying! Haven't I been saying that all this time?"

She took a deep breath that did nothing to make her face any less red, rolled her shoulders, flexed, and Catra was sure she could see a new vein pop out on her trunk-like bicep. Hope sighed, exchanging a frown with Duncan.

"She-Ra promo for Bash at the Beach, in three, two…"

The camera assistant held the clapper in front of the lens, and clicked it down.

Adora shot into action, pointing a trembling finger at the camera. "DO YOUUU… Scorpia, think that you've got… what I've—what it takes—FUCK! God… damn me!"

Hope stood up. "Cut!"

A collective sigh went through the room. Catra leaned back, watching Mermista groan and roll her eyes. Scorpia grimaced, pretending to look anywhere but at Adora. Mostly at the groupie in her lap. *What was her name again?*

It was the end of a night and the end of the European tour, and everyone was dead tired, eager to be back home in the States. All the matches were finished, all their bags were packed, all the TV interviews and promos were done… except for Adora's.

"Too gassed up," Lonnie muttered to a gloomy-faced Kyle.

"Come on, kid." Duncan, two-time world heavyweight champion in his day as Man-At-Arms, stepped forward. "I can tell you're working me here. Everybody can. Who're you foolin'?"

"I *know*," Adora groaned, snatching up the paper where she had her lines written down. "I know, okay? God damn it, just let me go again."

"Adora!" Hope said sharply, though her face never so much as shifted an inch. Adora stilled, clenching and unclenching her fists. "We'll be here all night at this rate. Just focus, reread the script. Do you need cue cards?"

"I don't need cue cards!"

"*Entschuldigung*," wheedled a voice from the door, slightly ajar. "*Hallo?*"

"Oop, I got it," Scorpia said, lifting the long-haired hippy off her lap and moving over to the door to position herself between the impromptu studio. "How can I help you, uhh, mister? *Herr*?"

"*Entschuldigung, das Reinigungspersonal fragt, wann Sie fertig sind*."

"Ooh, right, okay, uh…"

"*Wir brauchen das Zimmer.* Clean, okay? *Reinigung*." Somebody tried to slip past Scorpia, wearing the tell-tale dark-blue of the venue staff.

"Hold on, we're busy in here!" Scorpia gently ushered them back out, though with her mass the janitor might as well have been trying to move an oak branch. "The cleaners, uh, want the room," she translated to Hope.

"Adora…" Hope began.

"Jesus, at least give me a moment to read!"

"Listen, we're almost done, okay? Oh dear, where's DT when you need them… *wir*, err… *wir sind*… not ready. *Nicht klar, bitte!* Come back… later?"

Some muttering. "*Ich sag' Ihnen Bescheid*."

"No, yeah, great! Won't be long!" Scorpia hastily shut the door and leaned against it, puffing out a long breath.

"Kayfabe, Scorp!" Catra called over.

"It's not like you lot speak a lick of German!" Scorpia protested, eyes flitting between Catra and the groupie. *Perfuma, that was it.* "And it's not my fault our only translator already left for the airport!"

"Miss Droom, please refrain from interacting with the local personnel," Hope said icily. "Adora, are you ready?"

Adora was staring unseeingly at the paper in her hands, slowly crumpling it up. "Hold on…"

Catra groaned, hopping off the table and briskly taking Adora by the elbow, who gave an indignant grunt as she was lead off to the bathroom.

"Miss Gatia—" Hope sighed, sounding like she was at her wit's end.

"Just a second!" Catra shouted, slamming the door shut behind them.

"Catra," Adora huffed as Catra released her, now standing side by side in a stall. "I really can't have—"

"—me distracting you, yeah, I know." Catra reached into the neckline of her leotard, fishing out a sweat-soaked baggie of cocaine that stunk no worse than the rest of the rancid excuse for a bathroom they were huddled together in. Adora instantly caught on, quieting down and leaning close. She always did.

"One line," Catra warned in a mumble, priming a finger blindly at Adora. "Leave the rest for California."

“Yeah, yeah, I just—It’s the match, I can’t focus after that whole —”

“I know.” Catra snatched a prodigious amount of paper rolls from the graffitied dispenser, giving the top of it a cursory wipe-down. “So you fucking botched, get over it. Everyone does—and at a house show? It’s not like it will ever see the light of day.”

“I saw like… three camcorders in the crowd,” Adora sulked. “Everybody’s got those stupid handhelds these days. Next thing you know it’ll be on Late Night with Conan—”

“Sh.” Catra pressed a finger to Adora’s lips. “Shut up.”

“Mmf.”

Catra slowly peeled her finger away, and, maintaining eye-contact all the while, ran it between her own lips. She could see Adora’s pupils widen in an instant.

“Catra—”

Catra turned away, peeling the dime bag open and sorting the pitiful amount of cocaine out into two lines. It was a trembling affair, clumsy and slow—Catra couldn’t deny her own aches and woes from her match were starting to set in, burning into her thigh, spine and stabbing at her knees. She needed ice, after this. A ridiculous amount of ice.

She bent down, pressed her nostril shut and snorted the line up the other. The initial spark threw her back, straightening and bracing against the wonderful burn of it, part of her mindscape spilling into wonderful bliss.

The other half, squinting, riding out the blur of her heart beating out of her chest and settling back to the floor directed Adora in front of her, squeezing past each other. Adora sniffed her line up quickly, pressing the back of her hand to her nostrils.

“Mph—fuck…! Alright, alright…”

Catra rubbed her index finger into what was left of the white residue, wiping it against her gums. Part of her wanted to give in the wonderful high she was riding now—maybe ride Adora then and there, the promo outside and the urine-stained floors be damned. They had gone at it in worse circumstances, all things considered. It was certainly part of the reason why Adora seemed to be glowing to Catra right now, blinking into wakefulness.

"You good?"

"Yeah, I think… I think…"

Adora trailed off, breathing hoarsely. Catra had her hand on the taller woman's cheek, resting there, tentative, brushing softly and then pushing.

"Catra…" Hungry, inching closer—they were both feeling it, the flutter that followed the kick, throbbing in their stomachs and warming up their insides. Catra's other hand slipped under the fabric of Adora's skirt.

Catra knew damn well that if she kissed Adora now, like every part of her that wasn't her brain was urging her to, they would never make it out of the stall in time. They might not even catch their flight back to America.

Catra brushed the lingering white dust off Adora's nostrils, and slapped her.

"Owh! What the fuck—"

"Are you with me now?" Catra growled.

"What the fuck is your problem?"

Another smack. Adora retaliated, her full weight effortlessly pressing Catra into the wall.

"Let me tell you something—"

“There we have it,” Catra hissed, managing to keep the hoarse growl out of her voice that would’ve definitely sent all the wrong signals to Adora. Or right one, depending on a set of priorities which Catra herself wasn’t really sure about. “Now give me more.”

Adora blinked, licking her lips. “Of what?”

“Come on, aren’t you fucking She-Ra? Princess of god-damn power?”

“I… am—”

“So give me something!” Catra peeled her arm free, pushed Adora back and put another slap across her cheeks. “Tell me something!”

“I’ll tell you something!” Adora shot back, raising her voice.

“Let me tell you something, Scorpia!”

“I’ll fucking tell her something!”

A vein was throbbing in Adora’s forehead, those godly biceps of her trembling under the strain of her body’s tension. She was fired up to the nines. Catra dared one final push. “What’ve you got!?”

Adora shoved Catra into the wall with one-handed ease, leaning over her. “I’m gonna fucking *demolish* you if you hit me again.”

Catra cracked a grin, breathing heavily. Still watching Adora, she kicked the stall door open, gripping her by the shoulder and directing her back out.

“Good girl. Now get the fuck out there and make some money.”

Mermista

When Catra and Adora had vanished into the bathroom, it really was a coin toss whether they were doing a line, having a fight or fucking each other's brains out, as far as Mermista was concerned. Seeing Adora storming back out, nearly bulldozing Kyle and ordering the camera crew to start rolling, she had a guess.

"LET ME TELL YOU SOMETHING, SCORPIA!" Adora thundered, gesturing animatedly into the camera, wide-eyed and glistening with sweat. "You think you've got what it takes to best the unbested? To defeat the undefeated? Let me tell you something! You don't stand a chance in hell! You lack the strength, you lack the power—power that was given to me… by the lineage of Grayskull! And when I pin you, ONE, TWO, THREE, in the middle of that ring at Bash at the Beach, you will KNOW… the honour of Grayskull!"

"Cut! Very good, Adora." Hope was smiling, which was pretty much the highest praise you could expect from her. "That's a wrap. Please keep in mind, everyone, our plane leaves in six hours. Also, be aware the card for Bash at the Beach has been finalised. Mr. Duncan, if you wouldn't mind."

"Aye." Duncan slapped his knees, standing up and weaving his way through the bustling camera crew. All the wrestlers still in attendance—Kyle, Lonnie, Rogelio, Mermista, Sea Hawk, Catra and Adora—crowded around him.

"Good job, kid. Knew you had it in you," he said, pinching Adora's shoulder.

"Yeah! Yeah, yeah, yeah." Adora nodded like a jack in a box, flashing an unsubtle look at Catra, who had emerged far more quietly from the bathroom. "Just needed some, uh, motivation? Yeah. What's the card?"

"Like you need to ask," Catra mumbled, suddenly a great deal more sullen.

"Let's hear it!" Lonnie interjected.

Duncan unfolded a sheet of paper from his coffee-stained jeans, fishing out his glasses with the other and jutting them up his nose.

"Alright… first up, we've got…"

Frankfurt, Germany

Bundesautobahn 3

A rental car

"*Ugh*," Mermista groaned.

"Whatever is the matter, dearest?" Sea Hawk turned down the vocals of Michael Jackson's *Scream* blasting from the car radio, making eye contact through the rear view mirror. Mermista instantly looked away.

"Somebody didn't make the card again~" Flutterina pestered.

The only thing stopping Mermista from reaching forward and throttling Flutterina on the spot was the fact that Sea Hawk was the driver, and despite not having a show to wrestle on, Mermista wasn't looking to end her life going seventy on the German autobahn in a struggling Audi from the previous decade.

"Ah, but you *are* on the show! Behold!" And then Sea Hawk was reaching back, shoving a document he had somehow procured behind Hope's back in Mermista's face. Mermista didn't know whether to laugh at Flutterina's sheer panic as she leaned over to

help Sea Hawk keep the wheel steady or punch Sea Hawk for the fact that her life flashed before her fucking eyes.

"On the *fucking* road, Hawk!" Mermista hissed, slapping the paper down and driving her knee into his backrest. Kyle squeaked, gripping Lonnie's thigh, who just kept dozing through it all.

"Fear not!" Sea Hawk affirmed, brushing aside Flutterino's anxious hands. "I am rock steady! I am…"

Whatever he spouted next was drowned out by the blaring horn of a truck passing them by. Mermista sighed, unfurling the paper and staring at the card for perhaps the tenth time that night. And yep, as Sea Hawk had said, her name was on there alright.

ETHERIAN ELITE WRESTLING

BASH AT THE BEACH

SUNDAY, JULY 16TH, 1995

HUNTINGTON BEACH, CA

SEA HAWK (accompanied by MERMISTA MASOE) VS OCTAVIA (c)

For the EEW Heavyweight Championship

SHE-RA (c) VS SCORPIA

For the EEW Royal World Championship

CATRA (c) VS TUNG LASHOR

For the Horde Hardcore Championship

FROSTBITE (c) VS KYLE THE KLUTZ (accompanied by ROGELIO)

For the EEW Cruiserweight Championship

THE PRINCESSES (c) VS THE FORCE CAPTAINS

For the EEW Tag Team Championships

QUEEN GLIMMER (accompanied by THE TECHMASTER) VS LETHAL LONNIE (c)

For the EEW Television Championship

Accompanied by Mermista Masoe.

Accompanied.

"I'm playing the fucking *valet*," she groused, crumpling the paper up and tossing it at Kyle.

After years of trying to build herself as a singles star worthy of challenging for the world championships, all it would amount to was her playing Sea Hawk's sidekick, there to escort him to the ring and watch him wrestle as she stood on the outside, looking pretty or whatever the fuck.

She could see Hawk stroking his moustache. "Some would say there is a great deal of prestige in accompanying the number one contender to the ring."

Mermista threw her head back. "*Ugh*."

"What's more, you have your moment in the spotlight you so rightfully deserve—albeit it at my side—and the masses are sure to take notice!"

"But I don't *want* to become famous as a piece of shit valet. You realise if they *like* it, I'll be doing it more? And if I don't do anything with it, Hordak is just gonna write me off TV. I want to *wrestle*."

"Jesus, do you always complain this much?"

“Remind me when *you* last had TV time, Flutterina?” Mermista levelled her with an unimpressed stare. “Was it, like, 1992, or should I be aiming for the eighties?”

Flutterina huffed out an indignant sound, turning a page in her LIFE magazine and pointedly pretending to read it.

“Hard work pays off, Mermista! And when the moment comes, you must SEIZE it with both hands!” And in testament to this he threw his hands up, somehow not managing to commit gross vehicular manslaughter in the anxious few seconds where the steering wheel went unmanned.

“That’s easily said, *you’re* in the main event.”

Sea Hawk was stroking his moustache again. “Indeed, Scurvy’s negligence in bringing his colt through the diligent customs of our German friends proved most fortunate for me…”

“Whatever.” Mermista sagged back, trying and failing to find some comfort against the car door. “Wake me up when we make it to the airport. Or Sea Hawk gets us all killed, I guess.”

Chapter End Notes

Translations:

“Entschuldigung, das Reinigungspersonal fragt, wann Sie fertig sind.” — “Excuse me, the cleaning crew is wondering when you're done.”

“Wir brauchen das Zimmer.” — “We need the room.”

“Reinigung.” — “Cleaning.”

“Wir sind nicht klar, bitte.” — A poorly translated attempt at saying “We are not done, please.”

“Ich sag’ Ihnen Bescheid.” — “I’ll tell them.”

Chapter title is from Gold Dust Woman by Fleetwood Mac.

It Is My Time

Chapter Notes

Below follows a glossary for wrestling lingo that will appear in this chapter:

Kayfabe: The presentation of professional wrestling as being entirely legitimate or unscripted, and staying in-character.

Gassed: Being out of breath.

Over: This has several meanings. **Being over** means being loved by the fans. **Going over** means winning the match. **Putting someone else over** means losing to that someone.

Promo: An in-character interview or speech done by wrestlers to move a storyline forward, generate interest or promote a match.

Valet: A person who accompanies wrestlers to the ring as a sidekick. Generally not involved in the actual match unless they interfere.

Book: A **booker** plans the matches. To be **booked** as something is to be written as that. **Booking** refers to the writing of storylines and match-ups.

Finisher: A wrestler's signature move that usually leads to the pinfall or submission.

Spot: A pre-planned action or sequence in a match.

Card: The matches planned for a wrestling event. **Midcard** and **midcarders** refer to matches and wrestlers considered less prestigious than the main event.

Championships: Championships are referred to as a **championship**, **title**, **belt** or **strap** interchangeably, as they are represented by a belt.

Job: To job means to lose. **Jobbers** are wrestlers who generally lose a lot. From the phrase "to do your job".

Bury/burying: Lowering or losing a wrestler's status, popularity or credibility in the eyes of the fans.

Babyface: A wrestler who is generally considered 'good' or heroic in a wrestling match. Sometimes shortened to **face**.

Heel: The villain in a wrestling match.

Juice: Real blood during a wrestling match. Also called **colour**.

Staging Position: The curtained area where a wrestling event is being organised, broadcasted, and where the wrestlers are right before they come out for their match.

Hardcore Wrestling: A style of wrestling emphasising brutality, the use of items and real violence. Whereas normal matches have rules like no foreign objects and no interference on grounds of disqualification, hardcore matches generally don't have any rules.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

July 16th, 1995

Huntington Beach, California

The crowd of some nine thousand people rose to their feet as the sound of glass shattering played over the speakers, the volume turned up to a ridiculous level in an attempt to cancel out the wind. And as Lonnie came storming out to a driving guitar in minor key, wearing nothing but a sleeveless leather jacket and black booty shorts, the place came alive.

Then the speakers switched over to a grandiose orchestra of Beethoven's Ode to Joy, and out came Glimmer in her glittering purple singlet, closely followed by Bow in his custom midriff-exposed tuxedo and oversized flight goggles. The reaction was mixed this time, but excitement was high for the start of the event and the noise never wavered.

An array of beach-themed set pieces decorated the curtains from which the wrestlers emerged. Beach balls, shovels, a few buckets, a surfboard—a pretty minimalist affair on the whole. The beach itself was what counted, after all.

With Lonnie mean-mugging Glimmer like a wild dog and Glimmer haughtily ignoring Lonnie in favour of handing her crown off to Bow, they delegated themselves to their respective corners, and ring announcer Peekablue took centre stage.

"Ladies and gentlemen, good afternoon, and welcome to the EEW Bash at the BEACH!"

Loud cheers answered his address. True to the event's name, the squared circle was set up in the middle of a sandy beach, sparsely-fitted rafters squaring it off and a little wooden walkway forming the bridge between the wrestling ring and the backstage area. In the absence of seats, the crowd was packed densely together, sitting on each other's shoulders and climbing onto the roofs of their cars where possible.

"This first match, scheduled for one fall, is for the EEW Television Championship, introducing first, accompanied by the TECHMASTER, from Tokyo, Japan, weighing in at one hundred and forty-three pounds… QUEEN GLIMMER!"

Boos and cheers both—expected, when you had a beloved heel going up against an anti-hero like Lonnie. But whatever reservations someone might have about doing a pay-per-view on a beach of all places, it hardly seemed to matter when the crowd screamed twice as loud as any arena venue would have during Lonnie's introduction.

"And her opponent, from Knoxville, Tennessee, weighing in at one hundred and sixty-five pounds, she is the EEW Television Champion… LETHAL LONNIE!"

The bell rang, and they were off. Lonnie chopped the hell out of Glimmer's chest, 'stomped' her down into a corner and delivered a DDT for good measure, a classic move that involved driving your opponent's head into the mat. Glimmer complained to the referee, ducked and dived through the ropes and even hid underneath the ring, until Lonnie dragged her back out kicking and screaming.

It was an entertaining match-up. Lonnie had the crowd eating out of her hand as she strutted around, yelling profanities that the cameras luckily wouldn't pick up and inciting the crowd to jeer Glimmer even harder. The match spot came when Bow distracted the referee with some asinine complaints about workplace safety, allowing Glimmer to discreetly throw sand in Lonnie's eyes, roll her up and steal the victory, one-two-three.

"Here is your winner, and, NEW EEW Television Champion… QUEEN GLIMMER!"

The place exploded with boos and subsequent cheers as Glimmer hopped in Bow's arms, who ferried her off in a bridal carry while an enraged Lonnie chased them all the way to the backstage area. The 'backstage' consisted of several pavilion tents set up for the Staging Position, where they were broadcasting the event to the wider world, and one of the beach restaurants sectioned off last-minute for the wrestlers to use as a locker room.

A polite applause greeted them as they went through Staging and entered the cleared dining area, one after the other. Adora

gathered Bow and Glimmer up in a big bear hug, Hope came out to give Glimmer a handshake, and even Hordak, head of creative, briefly poked his head out from Staging to congratulate her.

"Nice one, Glim," Mermista said, fist-pumping Glimmer as she shuffled by, sweat-soaked and breathy with laughter.

"A stellar display of avarice and treachery!" Sea Hawk clapped Bow on the back. "Fine work, Bow!"

Bow snickered, unbuttoning his sweat-soaked suit jacket. "I think one of the kids in the crowd tried to slap me."

"God *damn* you're fast." Lonnie jostled Glimmer from behind.

Glimmer pivoted, grinning. "What, gassed already?"

Lonnie grinned back, and they clasped each other's hands firmly. "Nah, lookin' forward to Monday, though."

"Hey, so, I've been meaning to talk to you about that." Glimmer wiped her brow down and hung the Television Championship over her shoulder. "I think we could go for a few more spots next time around if we talked to Hordak about it. You know, get some actual wrestling in there."

Lonnie's smile never slipped, but it was painfully obvious to Mermista that she was starting to sweat from more than the match she just had and the sweltering heat.

"Still dropping the belt back to you, obviously," Glimmer quickly sussed. "But I think we can make some money with this!"

"Yeah, uh, we'll talk about it," Lonnie muttered. "I'm just gonna get some ice first, 'kay?"

Glimmer maintained her smile for as long as it took Lonnie to leave the room. Then she sagged, slipping down into the plastic chair next to Mermista.

"You wanna make something of this, you gotta convince Hordak, not her."

"I know," Glimmer sighed. "I just thought she'd be more cooperative. She heard the reaction out there!"

"I mean, I don't blame her, or anything." Mermista shrugged. "I'd wanna keep the title too."

"She's held it for *months*."

"And you're expecting *Lonnie* to put on a technical masterpiece with you."

Glimmer was quiet for a moment, drumming her fingers against the plate of the belt.

"What if I ask Hordak to book us in a match?"

Mermista paused, glancing aside.

Sea Hawk nodded slowly, sharing a look with Bow. "That would be a match-up for the ages."

"Maybe even for the TV title!" Glimmer added eagerly.

"Well…" Mermista hesitated. She knew Glimmer was a serious performer when the situation called for it, though the same went for half the roster. Hordak's booking reeked of the eighties, and a catastrophic amount of miscasting.

Not to mention the fact she was actively being buried as a valet.

"You *know* we'd be a draw."

Mermista raised her hands. "I'm obviously not gonna say no to that. Buuuuut I feel like you're forgetting about your rematch with Lonnie."

"I'll try to corner Hordak after the show!" Glimmer hopped off the chair, making for the showers. "This is great, Mermista!"

“It seems the answer to your woes has finally arrived!”

“Wishful thinking, Hawk.” Mermista looked away, raising her hand in greeting to Spinnerella and Netossa as they emerged, tag team gold over their shoulders. “‘Sup, ladies. Ready to kill it?”

“You bet.” Netossa squared her shoulders. “Time for some high flying, if you ask me.”

“How’s the mat?” Spinnerella glanced around, upnodding Bow. “Did you get to test it?”

“It seemed pretty bouncy! I think you’ll be fine.”

“Great.”

Hordak’s staff was beckoning them over from Staging, so Spinnerella and Netossa went on their way, exchanging a few amicable words with Cobalt and Grizzlor in passing. Loud disco music straight from the seventies started blaring over the distant speakers as they made their entrance. A thick television set on one of the tables switched over from its vignettes to a view of Peekablue, back in the centre of the ring.

“The following contest is scheduled for one fall, and is for the EEW Tag Team Championships!”

Adora left them to it, walking over to where Scorpia and Catra were sitting in the corner.

Sea Hawk leaned over. “Maybe we should endeavour a foray into the tag team division when Scurvy returns from his untimely incarceration. Perhaps Octavia can pair up with Leech!”

“And precisely *how* many tag team moves have you done in your life?”

“I’m a fast learner, dearest.”

"It's not going to happen, Hawk. One, you're not a tag team wrestler. Two, *I'm* not a tag team wrestler. Three, Hordak isn't going to *book* Scurvy after he brought a gun in his hand luggage to Germany. And *four*, Octavia isn't going to give up on her singles run just because you want to do tag team wrestling. She'd be fucking crazy to."

Sea Hawk scanned their immediate surroundings and leaned in conspiratorially. "I have it on good authority…" he began in a whisper, cupping a hand around his mouth. "…that she is dropping the belt tonight."

"You're—" Mermista bit her tongue, aware she raised her voice. She leaned in, hissing under her breath. "*You're going over?*"

Sea Hawk waggled his eyebrows meaningfully.

"Jesus, Sebastian, that's…" Mermista took a deep breath, forcing some cool into her voice. "That's pretty great." And yet, despite the earnest happiness she felt for him, it was unmistakably tinged with the sourness of knowing *how* it was going to happen.

"Indeed! And so I thought, who better to share the spotlight with than Mermista, princess of the isle, darling of the Pacific?"

Mermista blinked.

"Hold on, what?"

"That is to say, such a profound moment ought be shared between—"

Mermista took hold of the red bandana hanging around Sea Hawk's neck—a bonus of him always wearing his ring gear (and always being in character, depending on who you asked).

"Hawk," she drew out slowly, voice dangerously measured. "Did you ask Hordak to book me as your valet?"

"You know, I really think the term 'partner' might be a smidge more appropriate here—"

Mermista shoved him away and put her head in her hands. "*Ugh*. I can't believe you! You didn't think to fucking *ask* before *burying* me on live TV?"

"Far be it from me to lambaste someone else for their hyperboles, but I do think you're failing to see the bigger picture here, dearest."

"Oh yeah, *thank you* for writing me in as your side piece during your title victory, Hawk. Really, you're too kind. That whole singles run I was after? Don't worry, I can wait another few months."

"Heesh, calm your tits, Merm." And to Mermista's rising displeasure, Catra was sashaying over, leaving Scorpia and Adora to discussing their own match.

"Fuck off."

"Who put sand in your vagina?"

"Eat shit and die."

"Is it your spot on the card?" Deaf to Mermista's crude pleas, Catra sat down beside her, half-watching the screen where Netossa had Grizzlor wrapped up like a pretzel. "Flutterina's been chatty."

"I'm gonna toss her luggage in the sea."

"Her room number is 246." Catra glanced aside, caught Mermista's eye and shrugged. "What? Everyone needs a good ribbing now and then."

Mermista grimaced, reminding herself she should still be angry at Sea Hawk.

"Yeah, it's my spot on the fucking card. You know Hope told me I'd be headlining pay-per-views by the end of 1994 when I signed?"

Catra's mouth twisted sourly. "Hope's full of shit."

"I'm starting to realise that."

Peekablue's voice echoed through the television set and the speakers outside both. "*The winner of this bout, and STILL… EEW Tag Team Champions… Spinnerella and Netossa… THE PRINCESSES!"*

Grizzlor and Cobalt returned first. From their smiles, you wouldn't guess they had just eaten a loss, but then what else was new? They had a long night on the town ahead of them, courtesy of a fat paycheck. Another round of applause scattered through the Staging tent and the backstage restaurant as Spinnerella and Netossa came back, belts dragging behind them.

"Great job, guys! Nice selling, Spin!" Adora called after them.

"Wasn't selling," Spinnerella mumbled, tossing her belt on one of the tables and limping on.

"Thirty-five years of age and already on her way out," Sea Hawk observed. "Our sport's a sad state of affairs, betimes."

"Not me, bozo." Catra kicked her feet up. "I'm made of iron."

"I saw you cry like a baby when you tried to lie down last week," Mermista retorted drily.

"I was high."

"When was the last time you weren't high?"

"Uh, how about right now?

"Let's give it a few minutes."

"Bitch," Catra laughed.

The television screen switched over to a view of the studio they had all crammed into this morning, one after the other, to record the final set of promos. This time it was Kyle, tripping over his words as he promised to bring the pain to Frostbite with Rogelio standing at his shoulder. The fact that Kyle, a glorified jobber who couldn't cut a promo to save his life, was on the card and Mermista *wasn't* set anger and jealousy flaring up in her chest all over again.

"Why not try doing it like Rogelio?" Catra tapped the screen with her big toe. "Pretend to be Sea Hawk's partner or friend, mean mug everyone, you know… interfere a bit. Maybe Octavia's up for taking a spike?"

"Now now, I think pretending would hardly be necessary…" Sea Hawk said with a nervous laugh.

"Because we're supposed to be the faces," Mermista explained. "And I'm not looking to be the latest Samoan playing a crazy heel. That shit is, like, *so* overdone."

"More like you're not looking to get paid."

"You're lucky you're such a massive bitch. Whatever would you do as a babyface?"

"I don't know. Draw a bigger crowd than you?" Catra flashed a smirk and hopped back to her feet, headed for the kitchens.

Mermista's jaw tightened. Any other day, she might be ready to match the banter. But today…

Sea Hawk reached forward, turning the volume up. "Frosta looks to be running hot tonight."

On the screen, Double Trouble beckoned Frosta over, armed with a microphone and a toothy smile. *"Frostbite, darling, they say you've had a chip on your shoulder ever since Kyle the Klutz's*

actions at Hordemania, this past April! Tell me something, do you think you'll settle it tonight?"

Frosta turned to face the camera fully, and Mermista thought she could count the bloodshot lines in Frosta's eyes.

"KYLE!" Frosta shrieked into the microphone. *"YOU PIECE OF TRASH, tonight is the night I'm putting you on ice! And don't you even think about letting that MEATHEAD of yours, ROGELIO, get close to me, 'cause I'll LEAVE HIM OUT COLD TOO!"*

"If I were Kyle, I'd be shaking in my boots!" Sea Hawk slapped his knee. "Hah! Terrific promo! We're buying that girl some label after this!"

"Youngest champ in the company for a reason, I guess."

More wrestlers joined them as the ring announcer called out the match. Tung Lashor pulled up a chair, slurring an incoherent greeting. Netossa returned from the showers. Spinnerella had gone for a lie-down. She would probably be out until the next morning, considering the spots she had just gone through. Sweet Bee, Lonnie, Starla, some stooges that made up Scorpia's entrance escort, crew from Staging—soon they had a small crowd sitting in front of the television set, half in wrestling gear, half in swim gear.

"…scheduled for one fall, and is for the EEW Cruiserweight Championship! Introducing first, from Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania, weighing in at one hundred and twenty-five pounds… she is the EEW Cruiserweight Champion… FROSTBITE!"

Frosta practically sprinted towards the ring, diving under the bottom ropes and ascending one of the ringposts to gesticulate wildly at the crowd. It worked like a charm, receiving a fresh wave of even louder cheers.

"The boundless energy of youth!" Mermista hadn't missed the nervous glances Sea Hawk was tossing her way, amid his usual

loquacious drivel. "'Tis a sorry shame we require so many crutches to match the fire of our heyday."

Netossa tilted her head as Kyle made his entrance. "I've never seen her this worked up. You don't think…?"

"It is likely the cocaine present in her system."

Several heads turned. That two-thirds of the Etherian Elite Wrestling roster was running around coked up every show was common knowledge—just not a topic necessarily broached so brazenly in the presence of Staging staff. Which was part of the reason why, when Entrapta said it so casually, Mermista's blood turned cold.

Only part of the reason, however.

"Frosta is *high*?" she asked incredulously, leaning in close.

Entrapta nodded. "She said she was experiencing fatigue, so I procured some for her."

Mermista stood up abruptly, her chair nearly falling over. Sweet Bee and one of the cameramen instantly abandoned their seats, recognising hot waters for what they were.

"*You gave Frosta coke?*" she hissed, fisting up the front of Entrapta's shirt.

"Was that the wrong thing to do?" Entrapta's eyes moved from Mermista's face down to the hand gripping her shirt, and back again. "You guys do it all the time."

"She's a *kid*!" Netossa stood up next to Mermista. Twenty-one years old, really, but the majority of the roster had a solid decade on her.

Mermista groaned. "I swear, if she gets a heart attack in that ring, I'm going to fucking—"

“Whoa, back off!” Catra shoved her way between Entrapta and Mermista, tossing the six-pack she was bringing with her aside and tipping over a few of the chairs. “What’s your fucking problem?”

“This moron gave Frosta coke!” Mermista must have been jabbing her finger a little too angrily in Entrapta’s face, because Catra gave her a shove that sent her stumbling back.

“I said *back off*. Get out of her fucking face.”

But Mermista, a great deal broader than Catra, was already caroming around, giving Catra such a violent push that bundled her into Entrapta and almost sent both of them to the floor, had Catra not caught herself.

A second later, and Adora’s arms were around Catra, nearly suspending her above the ground as she wrestled her back. Sea Hawk, far less obtrusive but no less firm for it, eased Mermista back by her shoulders.

“Alright, ladies! This isn’t the time and place for it!”

Adora was whispering her own words of wisdom to her girlfriend. “Easy, Catra. Hope is right outside. Take a deep breath.”

“You wanna step in the showers, bitch?” Mermista grated, staring right past Sea Hawk and his broad frame at Catra. She was too worked up over this, over Frosta, over Sea Hawk and over her *god damn fucking spot on the card* to listen to reason, and the showers seemed like the perfect place for an outlet.

In the wrestling business, the showers were the place to settle things, and you either settled things by talking them through, or throwing hands over them. Mermista was pretty set on which of the two it would be.

But Catra laughed at her, wholeheartedly derisive. “*I* actually have a match to worry about. Can’t say the same for you.” Another taunting laugh. “Have fun playing groupie!”

Mermista bristled, but this time Netossa and Starla had the presence of mind to add their weight to Sea Hawk's bid at crowd control, preventing Mermista from slamming Catra into the floor. Catra took Entrapta by the shoulder once she had disentangled herself from Adora, dragging her into the back.

"I didn't mean to cause problems…" Entrapta was saying as she was led away, but Mermista didn't care to hear it. Instead she whirled around, picking up the first thing in front of her and throwing it at the wall. It happened to be one of the plastic chairs, one of the legs snapping off in tandem to Catra slamming the door shut.

"God *damn* it!" She hissed, slapping away Sea Hawk's worrying hands. "Fuck!"

"It's for the best you didn't tag her," Netossa sussed. "If she walked through Staging with a black eye, you'd get your ass fined."

"Catra wears that shit like a badge of fucking honour," Mermista groused.

"I meant Entrapta." Netossa met her stare. "You know Hordak has a soft spot for her."

Mermista didn't know what to say, groaning and slumping back down in a different chair.

Netossa sighed, sitting down next to her. "Listen, I'm just as mad as you are. Frosta is a sweet kid, and the next time somebody tries to give her blow I promise you I'm breaking their arm. But you can't start punking people out at a pay-per-view. You'll land your ass on the streets faster than you can say 'bump'."

"Wisdom for the ages," Sea Hawk nodded.

"I can't believe Catra is *defending* it," Mermista grated, watching Frosta wrestle circles around Kyle. "Imagine if I took Adora to the strip club? She'd be fucking pissed."

"Mostly over the fact that you didn't include her," Sea Hawk pointed out.

"Bad example, but you get me."

Netossa sighed again. For a moment, Mermista was afraid she'd go on another tangent about how to conduct yourself in the business with all the air of a wizened elder, but that was more Spinnerella's style.

"Just… not at pay-per-views, 'kay?"

"Hmph."

As they settled, traffic picked up. Wrestlers arrived from the back, pulled up chairs or went to bother Staging. Bow and Glimmer returned, while Scorpia left to find Catra and Adora. The little audience gathered around the television set, now renewed, watched as Frosta gave Kyle an Irish Whip into the corner and started pulling a table out from under the ring.

"The official is trying and failing to get control of this match, DT!" DT's commentary partner, Granamyr, said excitedly.

"Looks like Frostbite is trying to up ante and get a table in the ring!" DT chuckled. *"I think she's forgotten this is a regular match-up!"*

"What's gotten into her!?"

You'd love to know the answer to that, Mermista mused sourly.

"And here comes Frosbite's finisher! She calls this the Winter's Bane!"

A collective grunt of appreciation swept through the little audience as Frosta front-flipped off the top rope with Kyle on table, landing her leg across his chest and sending both of them straight through with the crack of snapping wood. As the bell rang and Kyle was declared winner by disqualification, you wouldn't think

Frosta had just lost by the way she was pumping her fists at the cheering crowd, screaming her lungs out. Netossa and Mermista shared a miserable look.

"Who let her do a table spot?" Sweet Bee asked.

"I heard Hope approve it back in Staging," Bow said.

Tallstar crushed his empty beer can, lobbing it at the bin. "A table spot before the hardcore match? I bet Catra's *pissed*."

"She's gonna wanna up the ante now," Mermista muttered.

Sea Hawk hesitated, flitting a look aside. "…is that so?"

"Well, *duh*. She probably had a few table spots planned. Now—"

Then Mermista paused, because she *knew* Hawk, and she *knew* that tone of voice.

So like the grinding guns of a warship veering around, Mermista sloooowly turned her head to stare at Sea Hawk's increasingly guilty profile. "*Yes*. Because she's got a *hardcore match*."

"Ah." The word emerged from Sea Hawk's throat only a little short of breath, beads of sweat notwithstanding.

"Hawk, *what* did you do?"

Hawk put his hands up in surrender. "*I* did nothing. I *did* however notice a discrepancy in my luggage, and the absence of some of my, hum, tools of the trade?"

Catra

After getting Entrapta situated with Scorpia, Catra swung by Tung Lashor, put her feline mask on and made her way back to the Staging Position. Adora had tried to catch her on her way, but Catra staunchly ignored her and her worried mumbling. Now she was waiting behind the curtain, amping herself up, listening to the din of the crowd. Kyle looked pretty miserable as he came shuffling through the curtain, arm slung around Rogelio's shoulder.

Frosta, less so.

"Did you see that Catra!? That was so brutal!"

"Nice spot, kid."

Frosta lingered, hoisting the Cruiserweight belt over her shoulder. "I bet you've got something even crazier planned!"

Catra nodded slowly, listening to Peekablue give Tung Lashor's introduction. "You could say that."

Frosta grinned, worming her way between Catra and the curtain. "Come onnn… give me something. Anything!"

Another cheer emanated from beyond the curtain, so Catra gently shoved Frosta aside. "Sounds like it's my time. Sorry, Frosty Flakes, you'll have to find out with the rest of them."

The first clean guitar notes rang out, and the crowd answered with their loudest cheer since the show had begun. Catra waited, breathed out, and when the ominous drums of Metallica's *Enter Sandman* hit, she pushed through the curtain.

Despite the thin fabric being a pitiful barrier, Catra could swear the noise of the crowd swelled even more as she emerged under the late afternoon sun. People cheered, pumped their fists in time to the drums and chanted her name disjointedly, pushing into one another and leaning over the barricades in their attempts at catching a glimpse of her.

Catra didn't stop to take it in. With the Horde Hardcore Championship belt secure around her waist, half a gram of cocaine burning a hole in her nostrils and the overdone pounding of Lars Ulrich's drums humming in her ears, Catra marched across the wooden walkway to the waiting ring.

Fuck Adora for treating her like she was made of glass. Fuck Hope for letting them do a table spot. Fuck Mermista, that fucking midcarder.

Tonight was her night.

"Making her way to the ring from El Paso, Texas, weighing in at one hundred and thirty-nine pounds… she is the Horde Hardcore Champion… CATRA!"

A sea of hands reached out from either side as she stalked outside the ring, trying to grab her hand, pat her shoulder or who-knows-what. Catra ignored them, a cold and calculated cliff against the sea of desperation and adoration.

"Say your prayers, little one, don't forget my son, to include everyoooone!"

The crowd was singing along now. Catra finally graced them with a look, watching their faces, their colourful signs, taking in their madness and making it her own. There was nothing like a hot crowd to get the blood running.

"I tuck you in, warm within, keep you free from sin, 'til he Sandman he comes!"

Catra hopped up to the ring apron and stepped between the ropes. Tung Lashor was waiting inside the ring, wearing his signature Ouroboros-emblazoned leather jacket and clawing at the air, going through his own psych-up rituals. He was a mountain of fat and muscles, his pinkish flush making him seem perpetually out of breath. Catra stared at him all the while as she crossed from one end of the ring to the other, mounting the ringpost and raising her fists to the crowd.

The crowd lights went out in favour of a single ring light, illuminating Catra and casting a long shadow behind her. The crowd's roar rose like a great wave.

"EEEXIIIIIT LIGHT! EEEENTEEER NIIIGHT!"

The worried faces of her friends and colleagues backstage, Hordak's angry admonishments, Hope's permanent disappointment in her—all of it melted away, leaving nothing but the overwhelming noise of the crowd, the ring, and her opponent.

Tonight was *hers*.

The bell rang, and Catra threw herself into it wholeheartedly. Some wrestlers prided themselves on making their moves look like they hurt while doing their utmost to protect their opponents from any serious damage. Some wrestlers had moves that hurt like hell but looked god-awful.

Catra and Tung Lashor left no room for error. You could call it a sign of mutual respect if you wanted to, but a better way to put it might be that they had an understanding. They prided themselves on having the most brutal matches on the card, on making the audience wince and cringe and stay glued to their screen for the entire twenty-minute timeslot they were allotted.

So when Lashor threw his forearm into Catra's cheek, it felt as though she had been clubbed with a piece of wood. And when Catra chopped Lashor across his own bare chest with the flat of her hand, the meaty smack was loud enough to send a gasp rippling through the audience.

But it was a hardcore match, so pretending to beat the lights out of each other only went so far. True to the theme of Bash at the Beach, she slammed a sand bucket over his head and landed a perfect dropkick that cracked the plastic and made the crowd coo in appreciation. As Lashor pulled back upright, he whacked her in the face with a surfboard, and broke a beach chair into pieces across her back for good measure.

The crowd was alive. A good portion of them was chanting, "Cee-dub-dub! Cee-dub-dub!", a callback to both her and Lashor's respective tenures in the Crimson Waste Wrestling territory. The aches of half a dozen previous matches this month alone and the strain of this match were dull, undeniably there, but still dim on her mind. Catra saw Lashor shove Peekablue and Double Trouble aside to pick up one of the steel chairs at ringside, brandishing it in both hands.

He knew. She knew. They both knew. It was time to kick things up a notch.

Mermista

Mermista had taken her fair share of steel chairs to the head before. Even now, she could viscerally recall the way the whole world went quiet for that brief second following the impact. She remembered the aftermath, realising she was suddenly lying on her back, her whole body tingling with pain down to her numb fingers and toes.

Thus, seeing Tung Lashor drive that steel chair into Catra's skull—without her even putting her hands up to soften the impact—sent shivers down her spine.

"Holy shit!" Tallstar laughed. "Look at that colour!"

Catra had gotten back up to her knees with blood pouring from her forehead. Mermista guessed she probably bladed herself, and *deep* too—enough to paint her whole face red and leave it dribbling down to the mat.

"Well I'll be, that could blind a woman, Granamyr!" DT exclaimed over commentary.

"It couldn't be any clearer who the most vicious woman in EEW is!"

"It looks like Lashor is setting up a table outside the ring. Things are getting spicy, here at Huntington Beach!"

"And here comes Catra! Catra from the top rope!"

Catra had slithered her way up to the third rope, and with blood dripping from her face, she wiped her eyes and jumped. A noise of shock and appreciation swept through the crowd as Catra flew through the air, twisting a full 360 degrees mid-flight before coming down *hard*, back-first on Tung Lashor. Any attentive eye could tell you Lashor raised his arms to catch her in a manner that kept the both of them perfectly safe.

"A corkscrew moonsault from the top rope! This woman is on another level!"

Bow sighed. "It's a wonder she does hardcore matches at all when she can move like that."

"Right?" Glimmer shook her head. "Do you get an extra digit on your paycheck for this stuff?"

"You don't," Adora said quietly.

"And a kip-up from Catra!"

Back on her feet, Catra dove under the ring, slowly pulling out her next trick.

"That's not real glass, is it?" Adora looked aside, her voice a little high. "That's sugar glass, right?"

Mermista didn't answer. She had a sinking feeling.

Naturally, the rest of the doped-up locker room held no such reservations. As Catra positioned the pane of glass over the table,

the pop from the crowd translated perfectly to the backstage audience.

“Look at that!”

“She’s so god damn *over*,” Glimmer sighed wistfully.

“Catra’s trying to die in the ring again, huh?” Tallstar nudged Starla. “Ten dollars says she goes through solo.”

“You’re on.”

Mermista resisted the urge to scoff. Catra had a way of getting on her nerves, sure, but that didn’t mean Mermista wanted her to have some freak accident in the ring. At the end of the day, they belonged to the same locker room, and that meant something, didn’t it?

With a few forearms thrown across the side of Tung Lashor’s face, Catra had him lying dazed across the glass-covered table. He did a decent job at pretending to be out of it, head lolling around uselessly and pawing at his sides. Catra clambered her way up the ring and up the ropes, all the way back to the ringpost where she started. She smacked her chest twice, yelling something just barely picked up by the ringside microphones. *“¡Ahora voy por ti!”*

“She’s not doing what I think she’s doing?” The commentary team chattered. *“This can only go wrong, folks! I don’t like it a damn bit!”*

Admittedly, despite all the danger and stupidity inherent to the stunt, it was hard to look away as Catra jumped feet first off the ringpost, sailing through the air for a space in time that dragged on forever. It was hard not to clench your teeth, to wince and to groan inwardly as Tung Lashor scrambled off the table, leaving Catra to fall through both the glass and the wooden table in a glorious mess of splinters and shards.

Mermista cringed. The crowd lost their minds.

Amid the clamour of it all, of the noise peaking the ringside microphones, the commentary team losing their minds and the excited hoots and bickering of the wrestlers backstage, she slowly glanced aside at Adora.

Adora, pale as death, glued to the screen, and entirely unable to avert her eyes.

Catra

Lying in a mess of glass, sand and pain, Catra could have easily remained there in relative peace and allowed the referee to throw up his arms in the 'X' sign to end the match—the signal to let the backstage crew know everything had gone horribly wrong and Catra really was injured, and probably in a lot of pain.

Which she was, no doubt about that.

Her first attempt at rolling around to better sell the impact shot such sharp daggers of agony through her lower back that she wouldn't be surprised if she had broken something in there. Definitely bruised, though.

But, if she allowed that to come to pass, she would be forgetting the most important rule in the business.

The show must go on.

So when Norwyn, the referee for the match, knelt over Catra and quietly asked her if she wanted to continue, she gave a subtle nod, pushed him aside, sucked the pain up and started floundering her way back to her feet.

"I don't believe it!" She could hear Double Trouble's excited prattling from the nearby commentary desk. "There's glass

everywhere, Catra's bleeding like a stuck pig, and I'm pretty sure my colleague just spilled his coffee down his crotch! If there was a roof on this place, it'd be blown right off!"

Lashor stopped his showboating and made a grab for Catra. Catra, a little sluggish from the pain burning through her body, ducked under it, staggered a step, and made a desperate slide back into the ring. Lashor was hot on her heels, and soon they were bouncing into the ropes again.

"Good juice," Lashor grunted sluggishly as he reversed her Irish Whip. "Gimme some."

Catra hooked her arms under the ropes, halting her momentum. She wiped her hand down her face, stared at the thick smear of blood, felt the warm stickiness of much more of it still trailing from her forehead and somewhere along her sides, where the glass must have dug in. She listened to the incoherent mess of shouting from every side of the arena.

It hurt. It hurt a *lot*, but in moments like these, there was no drug on earth that could hold a candle to the likes of adrenaline. And there was no fuel for the fire like thousands of people screaming your name at the top of their lungs.

Catra might not be a six-foot gold amazon like Adora, have muscles to spare like Adora or a god damn fucking family legacy like the wrestling lineage of *He-Man* and *Grayskull* to rely on, like *Adora*, but she would inevitably have the crowd wrapped around her finger all the same.

More juice? Well, if you insist.

Adora

Adora wanted to look away. She couldn't look away.

The only thing stopping her from marching into Staging and screaming at Hope and Hordak to end the match was the fact she knew that it would be a futile effort.

The only thing stopping her from marching out into the ring herself was the undeniable disappointment and anger Catra would hold towards her afterwards. The fact that it'd be her paycheck, kayfabe and maybe even her job on the line was a small afterthought, if she was being honest with herself. Life without a college education and a *curriculum vitae* that didn't really extend beyond a decade of amateur and professional wrestling wasn't one filled with prospects.

So Adora watched the television screen, tuning out the inflammatory comments of her colleagues that would definitely lead to a few bloody noses if she started putting stock in them. She watched as Catra came out with a slight limp, how she staggered her way into the ropes during the criss-cross and how she had took one of the foulest chair shots to the dome Adora had ever seen.

It was a small consolation that Catra was the one dishing out chairshots now, busting Tung Lashor's brow wide open and peppering his back with enough hits to land a few dents in the metal.

When they brought a second table out, Adora took a fortifying breath.

Why couldn't Catra play it safe, like Adora did? She didn't need to get whacked on the head with a steel chair three days a week, or cut her back open on glass or barbed wire or *dive off a fucking ladder for that matter*. Didn't she *care*? Adora certainly cared—she prided herself on being a safe worker, for her opponent and herself both. She had her eyes firmly set on the future, and a comfortable retirement that didn't involve crutches for the rest of her life.

But *no*. Catra had to insist on stiffing it out every match, on getting her forehead cut open and swallowing enough painkillers to spend the next day in a drugged-up daze.

Adora blinked. Catra was squirting out a bottle of *something* onto the table.

"Is that…?" she began, eyes drifting aside. Mermista was glaring at Sea Hawk. Sea Hawk couldn't have looked more guilty if you put him in a pillory.

"What happened?" Adora breathed. She wasn't sure if she should be angry or scared.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. "Ah. You see. Catra…appears to have commandeered my supply of lighter fluid… without letting me know, mind! I thought nothing of it, but…"

Something knotted up, wound tight like a constricting vine. Maybe Adora's stomach, maybe her heart, or maybe it was just a side-effect of the sudden coldness that enveloped her, but she ignored Sea Hawk as Mermista pulled him into a private conference with a murderous look, because the table Catra just so generously drenched in lighter fluid lit up in flames.

Adora wanted to hit Sea Hawk. She wanted to hit Mermista too, though really she just wanted to hit *something*. Maybe she should just be laying off the steroids. Especially with Catra throwing a tantrum on live TV every week.

Lashor and Catra went at it again as the audience happily chanted *"You sick fuck!"* over and over. And then suddenly Lashor was hoisting Catra up, her legs around his shoulders, lifted her high into the air.

Selfishly, Adora felt like she was the one falling as Catra was thrown into the burning table.

Chapter End Notes

Translations:

“¡Ahora voy por ti!” — “Now I’m coming for you!”

Chapter title is from Dominik Mysterio's entrance theme.

Nobody Better Than Me

Chapter Notes

Below follows a glossary for wrestling lingo that will appear in this chapter:

Kayfabe: The presentation of professional wrestling as being entirely legitimate or unscripted, and staying in-character.

Shoot: Something real, or the truth. **Shooting** means hitting somebody for real (also called **stiffing**) or speaking the truth.

Heat: The reaction of the fans.

Over: This has several meanings. **Being over** means being loved by the fans. **Going over** means winning the match. **Putting someone else over** means losing to that someone.

Promo: An in-character interview or speech done by wrestlers to move a storyline forward, generate interest or promote a match.

Valet: A person who accompanies wrestlers to the ring as a sidekick. Generally not involved in the actual match unless they interfere.

Finisher: A wrestler's signature move that usually leads to the pinfall or submission.

Spot: A pre-planned action or sequence in a match.

Card: The matches planned for a wrestling event. **Midcard** and **midcarders** refer to matches and wrestlers considered less prestigious than the main event.

Championships: Championships are referred to as a **championship**, **title**, **belt** or **strap** interchangeably, as they are represented by a belt.

Babyface: A wrestler who is generally considered 'good' or heroic in a wrestling match. Sometimes shortened to **face**.

Heel: The villain in a wrestling match.

Staging Position: The curtained area where a wrestling event is being organised, broadcasted, and where the wrestlers are right before they come out for their match.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista

It came as no surprise that Catra (and by virtue of association, Tung Lashor) got the loudest reaction of the night, holding up her dented steel chair in victory in one hand and wiping blood out of her eyes with the other. There was something morbidly funny about the Hardcore champion generally taking the worst bumps but still retaining the belt. Kind of like the whole match being a bragging contest of who could take the most punishment, rather than dish it out.

And when Catra was your opponent, the cards were stacked pretty high against you. Not that Tung Lashor minded. The man could take enough punishment for three and was pretty much Catra's favourite opponent to share a ring with, which meant the paychecks kept coming. So Catra and him shook hands backstage, congratulated each other on a stellar match and went to find a doctor, stat.

Now Catra was sitting backwards on the same dented chair she had brought with her out of the ring, shirt and bra tossed aside so the medical staff could extract the smaller shards of glass out of

her back with a set of pliers. The older bruises and scarring Mermista saw there had an ugly look about them.

Hordak was giving her a dressing down for the ages. Most other wrestlers were idly watching, pretending not to. Adora hadn't an ounce of subtlety, hovering nearby with her hands entangled in the skirt of her ring gear in that anxious *I-need-to-do-something* way of hers.

Sea Hawk kept himself conspicuously quiet following the burning table spot. It hadn't gone too badly, all things considered; first-degree burns on Catra's arm was the most egregious result of the whole debacle. And it wasn't even all that much 'out there', compared to the stuff Catra usually got up to. Still, as far as Mermista was concerned, he wasn't exactly racking up a healthy credit score.

"They are *still* picking glass out of the sand. We've had to run intermission for five minutes. Do you have the *slightest* notion of the severity of this… this *gross misconduct*?" Hordak scoffed, tossing a set of indistinct papers at Catra's feet. Her blue eye darted down to it and back up to Hordak, the other covered by an ice pack. "If we get a citation from the DCA, that is coming out of *your* paycheck."

Catra winced as the doctor finally pried the last piece of glass out of her back, clenching her teeth together.

"You're being fined," Hordak growled, drawing himself up. "Fifteen hundred dollars, for failing to run this ludicrous idea by production. The next time this sort of nonsense occurs, I am *tripling* it. Do I make myself clear?"

"Crystal," Catra grunted sourly, fingers flexing into her ice pack.

The doctor took Hordak's place as he left for Staging, glue at the ready for the cut in Catra's forehead. Chatter started bubbling up as some of the tension left the room.

"*Fifteen*," Glimmer hissed in quiet echo. "Jesus wept."

Mermista raised her eyebrow at Catra. “You didn’t think to run it by Hope?”

Catra’s visible eye flitted over to her. “And have her say no?”

“And spare yourself a fine,” Mermista deadpanned.

“How about you spare me the lecture instead, Masoe.” Catra upnodded the doctor hovering over her. “What do you got for me, doc?”

“I can check you in at the local hospital, get that leg looked at. It’ll give the rest of these injuries time to heal.” He leaned over her, pushing the ice pack aside. “Or, I can give you vic and surtures.”

“TV tapings tomorrow,” Catra mumbled. “I’ll take the painkillers.”

The doctor hummed something non-committal. Even now, Mermista could hardly blame Catra. A fat fine on your record, a belt on your shoulders and television tapings coming up? Nothing for it but to bite down.

Neither was she surprised to see a *licensed medical professional* happily sign Catra off to throw her body back into the grinder. The doctors that Hordak pulled into his venues were very clearly instructed from the start that they were there to make sure the wrestlers kept wrestling, not to write them off to hospitals. And the wrestlers couldn’t even fault them for it—they wanted to keep wrestling just as much as Hordak did, because a hospital meant no salary, and stacking bills.

“Do you want to have a match with me, Catra?” Adora asked, daring to inch closer now that Hordak wasn’t there anymore. “I can ask Hope—once you drop the strap, you could run an angle with me. They’re not gonna say no to me.”

Catra sized Adora up, the movement drawing a noise of chagrin from the doctor taping up her forehead. Now in her ring gear,

Adora looked every bit the warrior princess her She-Ra gimmick was meant to be, splendidly awesome in every way.

"And eat a pin to you in a five minute squash? No thanks, princess."

"So I'll ask for a bigger slot, make it a real bout!" Adora pressed. "They don't put me with a lot of high flyers, you know, we could…"

Mermista left them to it.

She knew just as well as Catra—and even Adora, for that matter—that they would never let Catra pose a legitimate on-screen threat to the golden goose of the company, that being She-Ra. That was strictly reserved for humble monster heels that didn't require micromanaging every hour of the day.

Speaking of, on the way to the showers Mermista found Scorpia, already wearing her red ring gear, cosied up with that girl from Germany. Scorpia had come up with the wonderful idea of flying her with the rest of the crew back to America, and apparently nobody had taken the initiative to talk some sense into her.

"Kayfabe is fucking dead in the water, huh."

To her credit, Scorpia didn't shove Perfuma aside like a kid caught with their hand in the cookie jar (this time). "She was already in on the business before I met her!" she protested.

"Whatever, dude. I don't really care. Have you seen Hawk or Octavia around?"

Scorpia jerked her thumb over her shoulder. "Showers. Sounded like business."

Mermista raised her eyebrow. "The good or the bad kind?"

"Oh gosh. Good? I'm not really sure. You can usually tell when it's bad with Octavia…"

“Scorpia!” one of the roadies called down the hallway. “The ring’s ready for you! Playing your music in twenty!”

Scorpia blinked. “Minutes?”

“Seconds!”

“Oh gosh, right, okay.” Now she moved Perfuma aside with as much ease as she might have moved a doll, stood up, brushed herself down and *braced*.

There was something scary about the way the biggest, most musclebound woman Mermista had ever seen (apart from Huntara’s old vignettes) could switch from being the locker room’s most bubbly personality to Demon Scorpia, as her gimmick entailed. She stood a little taller, her muscles bulged outward when she flexed, her smile melted away before a menacing, lifeless stare, and the last bit of warmth fled the room.

“Good luck~” Perfuma beamed, unshaken by the display. “I’m totally rooting for you.”

Scorpia grunted something and marched on to Staging. Mermista paused, briefly, contemplating whether she should intrude on Hawk and Octavia. No reason to if it was good business, and if it was bad? Well, Hawk probably had it coming.

So she made her way back to the dining, slotting in with the rest to watch the television screen.

Scorpia’s entrance was a great deal more spectacular when you could turn off all the lights in the arena and follow her with a spotlight. Still, they managed to make something of it. To the chilling intro notes of Slayer’s *South of Heaven* echoing across the beach, a group of robed torchbearers emerged, lining up on either side of the walkway. Next came Scorpia, a smoke machine billowing ominous grey clouds around her feet. She towered over her stooges, filling the screen with her presence, and the audience cheered and booed their appreciation.

"We are in the presence… of demons, DT," Granamyr intoned. *"She-Ra has a real fight ahead of her."*

"The following contest is scheduled for one fall, and is for the EEW Royal World Championship! Entering first, the challenger, from parts unknown, weighing in at two hundred and seventy pounds… SCORPIA!"

If Scorpia's entrance was meant to be all hellfire and brimstone, Adora's was a regular ray of sunshine. The lights turned back on, tall sparklers went off, and her music played.

"We're warriors!"

"And her opponent, from Dallas, Texas, weighing in at two hundred pounds, she is the EEW Royal World Champion… She-Ra, Princess of Power!"

"What a babyface," Starla joked lightly.

And it was true. Adora struck the ideal image of a hero as she made her way to the ring, wearing a bright gold tiara, waving at the crowd, slapping their outstretched hands in passing and even taking the time to pose for a picture with a kid in the crowd.

"We're on the edge of greatness, turning darkness to light!"

Maybe the whole "stay in school and eat your vitamins!" hero gimmick was getting to be a little outdated, but who was gonna tell Hordak that? Certainly not Mermista. She had her own on-screen presence to worry about.

The bell rang, and the two locked up. Now, with all the pomp over and done with, it was a lot of oiled-up meat moving in that ring. Adora was tall, but Scorpia was taller. Adora was *big*, but Scorpia was *massive*.

They made a relatively standard affair of it, lasting twenty minutes, give or take. Scorpia did a wonderful job at playing the no-selling monster heel, relentlessly pursuing Adora around the

ring as the heroine tried to mount some form of offence that could topple the white-haired giant. Scorpia drew a lot of heat when she squeezed Adora up in the Scorpion Deathlock, a submission hold that had previously forced some of the most seasoned of babyfaces into tapping out.

"But folks, I don't think this is it just yet!" DT said over commentary. *"She-Ra is shaking her head, shaking no! Look at this!"*

"That's the power of Grayskull! She-Ra is feeling it, like her brother, He-Man, once did before her! This is it!"

It was a finish done a hundred times. You could mutter about originality, predictability and whatever the fuck else—it was hard to argue with results, and the result of Adora lifting Scorpia up over her head and press-slamming her into the mat was nine thousand voices cheering her name.

"She-Ra! She-Ra! She-Ra!"

"Here is your winner, and STILL… EEW Royal World Champion… SHEEEEE-RAAAAA!"

And just like that, there was only one match left on the card. Mermista felt like she was about to make the walk to the gallows. *When the priest comes to read me the last rites,* something something *last sights, of a world that has gone very wrong for me.*

Maybe she really was being dramatic. Maybe this was just a one-time gig, and after this she would be back to comfortably wrestling on the weekly midcard.

Just a one-time gig, yeah.

On the main event.

Of a pay-per-view.

Mermista drew a deep breath, held it, considered the alternative of no television time at all, considered going homeless with nineteen thousand left in medical expenses, and pushed it back out.

Time to make money.

If Sea Hawk had the tendency to misread a room, he could fill one with his presence alone. If his exaggerated theatrics had a way of coming across as obnoxious in public, they lent themselves to his athleticism in the ring. If he had a somewhat off-putting syntax in everyday conversation, it only made his killer promos that much more enthralling.

All in all, it wasn't hard to see why people referred to Sea Hawk as someone genetically engineered to be the perfect pro wrestler.

And if that wasn't enough, Mermista was harbouring a sneaking suspicion that he only took coke *after* a show was already finished.

The last-minute promos were quickly rattled off. Mermista put on her fiercest scowl, standing with her arms folded next to Sea Hawk as he vowed to skewer Octavia like the whalers of old and pin her, one-two-three. They shook hands with Octavia afterwards, best of luck out there, watch my hip, yada yada, and then they found themselves in Staging.

Mermista tuned out the bombastic drums and horns that made up Octavia's entrance, standing by as Sea Hawk gave some last minute instructions to one of the operators at Staging.

"…do a pirouette when I enter. Try to zoom the hard cam out as I do, I'll give a fine pose and Mermista can step into view with her own pose… what were you thinking, Mermista?"

“I’ll do this, like, thing with my hair. It’ll look really good.”

“Wonderful! And I believe that’s us!”

They dimmed the lights outside, to far greater effect now that the day had crawled into its twilight hour. The audience hushed up, Octavia’s music faded out, and Freddie Mercury’s voice sounded out over the speakers.

“Tonight… I’m gonna have myself…”

“Ready, dearest?”

“…a real good time…”

“As ready as I’ll ever be, I guess.”

The crowd’s voices rose, singing along in echoing harmony. The noise swelled, and Mermista had to admit it sparked a flame of excitement within her. Wrestlers lived and died for the business, the stage, the fans, and she was no different.

“And the world… I’ll turn it inside out, yeah…”

“Chin up! Who knows what secrets the evening yet withholds from us!”

“I’m floating around in ecstasy, so—”

Mermista frowned up at him. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

“Don’t! Stop me now!”

“Nothing!”

“Don’t stop me!”

“What—”

“No time for that! ADVENTURE!”

"'Cause I'm having a good time, having a good time!"

Sea Hawk pretty much exploded through the curtains, leaping onto the walkway to a resounding cheer. Mermista shook her head, donned her best no-bullshit expression, and followed him through.

It was a *task* to both keep up with Sea Hawk as he pranced to and fro on the walkway, waving at fans and slapping hands *and* still maintain a semblance of collected cool. Similarly, it took some effort to not let her dispassionate stare twist into a sullen scowl when the thought that she wanted to have her own entrance on a stage like this wormed its way into her brain.

Then some fans in the crowd called her name, and she pushed those doubts aside.

They posed for the hard cam, the fixed main camera you could always rely on to broadcast whatever you wanted the fans to see to the wider world, and let Peekablue step up.

"The following contest is scheduled for one fall, and it is for the EEW Heavyweight Championship! Introducing first, from Miami, Florida, weighing in at one hundred and sixty-five pounds, she is the EEW Heavyweight Champion… OCTAVIA!"

Octavia stepped forward, raising her arms at the crowd with a roar. A sea of boos answered her, the loudest of the night. Octavia had done exemplary work as a heel, hardly even needing to work for her heat—not that she didn't. She hurled a colourful array of expletives at the crowd, spat at a kid, and naturally threatened to beat the fans up if they dared step over the barricades. All part and parcel, but after seeing her walk in and out of every show with the Heavyweight strap still over her shoulder for the past four months, people were downright itching to see the title change hands.

"And her opponent, the challenger, accompanied by Mermista Masoe… from Venice Beach, California, weighing in at two

hundred and twenty-one pounds… SEA HAWK!”

Mermista was sure it was as loud a response as the one She-Ra received, and that counted for something—*especially* at the end of a show. A hated heel, a beloved babyface, a title match following the high of She-Ra’s victory over Scorpia, and a California native to boot? It was a no-brainer to have him in the main event, and Mermista didn’t resent him that or the impending victory one bit.

She sighed, watching him drink in the adulation. Not one bit.

“Alright, out of the ring, Mermista!” The referee, Norwyn, waved her off. Mermista threw Octavia a withering glare and stepped between the ropes, hopping down to the padding outside. Norwyn gestured for the bell to be rung, and the match was underway. True to his character, Sea Hawk tried to goad Octavia into the test of strength, only to receive a rapid kick to the midsection that had them punch and lock-up, wrestling each other back and forth into the corners until Sea Hawk threw her into the ropes. They kept up the fast-paced momentum, from tackle to arm drag and back into the ropes.

Mermista paced around the side of the ring, shouting encouragements and pounding her fist on the mat when she decided the ref wasn’t paying enough attention. She didn’t *like* playing the valet, but a gig at Bright Moon Stars back in the late eighties had taught her enough to fill the role aptly.

She was still conflicted on whether she should try and put herself more into the camera shots when Sea Hawk, up on the second rope, was precipitously kicked off by Octavia, turning over mid-air and crumbling down to the sandy padding outside. Mermista ran over, crouching down at his side where he was lying curled up.

“You good?” and then, a little quieter so the fans or cameras wouldn’t hear, “That looked nasty, dude.”

Sea Hawk turned over to look at her, face red and sweaty. “…it was.”

Mermista's eyes widened. "Oh shit. Is it your hip? What happened?"

"Come on, Masoe, get away from him! No interfering!" Norwyn yelled at her.

Sea Hawk tried to stand, one hand clutching the ropes, but his legs instantly gave in and down he went again. Mermista hissed "stay down" and jumped up on the apron, beckoning Norwyn over.

"It's legit, Norwyn," she muttered under her breath, giving her head a quick shake when Octavia started lumbering over. Octavia, thankfully, got the message quick, opting to instead draw attention from the crowd by making obscene gestures at them.

"You shootin' with me, kid?"

"Not one bit."

Norwyn turned away, hastily throwing his arms up in an 'X' sign towards the backstage—a signal that universally meant a wrestler was unable to continue, and without the crowd ever being the wiser. Already, Hordak, Hope and several assistant stooges were bundling out of Staging to take a look at the situation.

"I think I tore my quads," Hawk was explaining in a pitched voice, awkwardly sat up against the side of the ring. "A bad landing on my end, I do admit…"

Mermista winced, sucking in a sharp breath. Depending, an injury like that could write Sea Hawk off for months. Months spent with a finger up his ass, with stacking medical bills, no paycheck and, knowing Hordak, barely anything to help keep you afloat. A hundred dollars a week, tops—and right when they were giving the man a push?

"I guess your boy didn't have what it takes after all! Why not try kissing it better?" Octavia shouted over. Mermista paused—was she really taunting her about this *now*?—but that pause only

lasted half a second. Then she went through the ropes, squared her shoulders and got up in Octavia's face.

"It's a shoot, you stupid bitch," Mermista hissed, fists balled at her sides.

"And now the groupie wants to play tough!" Octavia shouted. Then, under her breath, "shove me."

Call it instinct, or the fact that Mermista didn't need much encouragement, but she gave Octavia a hard shove. Octavia came back around, shoving Mermista right back. "You want some!? I'll put *you* on the stretcher next!"

Mermista caught on. Improvisation was a necessary skill in the business, one you needed if you wanted to stay afloat. The fans wanted action, and they weren't gonna get it from Hordak arguing over a squirming, injured Sea Hawk. She gave Octavia another shove, and now Norwyn wormed his way between them, several ringside stooges at his side to help keep the two women apart.

"This on the card?" Norwyn asked, eyes darting between Mermista and Octavia as they fake-struggled against the restraining arms of the staff.

"I need a fucking match, don't I?" Octavia growled, and this time Mermista felt something different altogether. A light feeling that had the suspicious bearing of hope, of a stroke of luck—that she might have her pay-per-view bout after all.

And then the guilt, that she was stealing Sea Hawk's opportunity out from under him.

Norwyn glanced at her. "Are you alright to compete, Mermista? I'll run it by Hordak—"

Mermista yanked herself free and slid under the ropes back out of the ring, jogging over to where they were hauling Sea Hawk off the beach and into Staging. Hordak bickered with Hope all the while, understandably fuming.

“Hawk.” Mermista forced the whole procession to a halt. “Octavia wants me in… in the ring with her. Are you… like, okay with that…?”

Sea Hawk blinked up at her.

“I mean, it’s your spot. I won’t if you—”

“Mermista, dearest,” Sea Hawk gritted his teeth, though he somehow managed to smile through the pain—a genuine smile, the sort she knew were only reserved for her. “Nothing would make me happier.”

Mermista breathed out a hasty smile, and turned. “Hordak—”

“Octavia wants Mermista, Mr. Hordak,” Norwyn said, coming up behind her.

Hordak stared at them, grinding his teeth to dust. Then he glanced past them, at the jeering and cheering fans. Mermista listened…

“Ma-soe, Ma-soe, Ma-soe!”

“Get in the ring!” he snarled, and it was decided.

A hundred thoughts flitted through Mermista’s head right then. A thousand. *I have to wrestle. I’m not ready. I didn’t tape my wrists up. I didn’t pad my knees. They’re chanting my name. We didn’t prepare anything. I’m getting a title shot. It’s a pay-per-view. I’m gonna bomb. We’re bound to botch. This is fucked. I need coke for this.*

And one above them all.

I’m never getting another shot like this.

“Ladies and gentlemen!” Peekablue’s voice echoed around the beach. “Unfortunately, Sea Hawk has sustained a grievous injury and is unable to compete at this time!”

Loud boos answered him. Octavia strutted around the ring like a peacock, mocking the crowd and mimicking crying at Mermista.

"However, I have just been informed that we have found a new challenger for Octavia!" The boos were already switching over to cheers. Mermista rolled her shoulders, and started pacing back to the ring. "From the Isle of Samoa, weighing in at one hundred and seventy-five pounds… MERMISTA, MASOE!"

Mermista stepped between the ropes right as the bell rang, and instantly locked up with Octavia.

There wasn't anything else to do. At times, you needed to call it in the ring; improvise. Work around a botch, work around a miscommunication, perform a few moves on the fly—it was nothing new to any seasoned wrestler, and certainly not Mermista. Hell, she had gone through entire sequences with nothing but hunch, instinct and chemistry before.

Improvising an entire match? At a pay-per-view?

In the *main event*?

She knew it as soon as she had slipped between the ropes: this could only go wrong.

But, like watching a car crash in slow-motion, Mermista could only do what needed be done, and locked up with Octavia.

"I get the heat," Octavia huffed rapidly under her breath as they wrestled back and forth. "Fire back at Norwyn's signal, yeah?"

"Yeah," Mermista grunted. The noise of the fans had died down as they had gone back and forth across the ring.

"Watch the boot." And just like that, Octavia hooked her knee, wrapped Mermista's arm around her neck and slammed her overhead into the mat. Mermista had maybe a quarter of a second to orient herself and hold on for dear life before she was flipped over.

And god *damn*, but Mermista hadn't been lying to herself—she hadn't been ready. The impact of the mat drove the air from her lungs in a breathless cough, pain stabbing across her neck and upper back.

"Octavia with an explosive fisherman suplex!" Mermista was close enough to pick out tidbits of DT's commentary from the announcer's desk. "Mermista looks rattled!"

Octavia grabbed a fistful of Mermista's hair to haul her back up. Obviously, lifting somebody off the floor by their hair alone was downright impossible—in fact, Mermista was pretty much doing all the work in sitting up, getting her knees under her and rising to her feet.

Ever since the late eighties and, if you were a critic, earlier still, it was an open secret that professional wrestling wasn't a competitive sport. People knew it was rehearsed, planned ahead of time, that they used open fists and what-have-you. That Octavia was able to scoop Mermista off her feet and slam her upside-down back into the mat was nothing short of cooperation.

It was for the sake of the fans that they kept up kayfabe, that they pretended to hate each other's guts and immerse themselves so deeply into these characters that the line between their real lives and in-ring personas blurred dangerously. But what *was* real was the physicality. Some liked to say you wouldn't understand it until you saw it, some claimed it would go over your head until you attended a match in person, not on a dingy TV screen, and *heard* the loud reverberations of the padded wooden mat as Mermista bounced into it with a very real wince.

Mermista knew different. You wouldn't truly understand the sport until you got your ass tossed around from one side of the ring to the other, until your chest was chopped an ugly shade of red, until you heard the deafening screams of a thousand fans chanting your name. And that moment, where their adulation and their belief in you lifted you to the top of the world, that intoxicating euphoria was worth everything.

Octavia tossed Mermista around for some five minutes with minuscule resistance until Norwyn gave the signal, and the tone of the match shifted.

"Exploder suplex from Mermista!" Granamyr shouted into his headset. "And a hurricanrana! Mermista with a hurricanrana! She's hearing the fans, DT, and she's feeling them!"

"Looks like our princess has found a second wind…! But I doubt that'll be enough to topple our Heavyweight Champion."

The adrenaline had long kicked in, and now Mermista was fighting her way through a dozen aches, through the fatigue settling into her muscles. She gripped the ring ropes, hopped on top of them and launched off with a vicious clothesline that had their chests collide to a meaty slap. Her left ear was ringing, her knees were throbbing, but when Octavia grunted for her to do a belly-to-belly suplex there was nothing to do but to do it, and the sight of Octavia getting tossed through the air enticed such a cheer from the crowd that Mermista popped right back up for more.

Only to get hit by a truck.

"A spear! A spear from Octavia!"

Or rather, to get hit by Octavia's finisher, which consisted of Octavia diving shoulder-first into Mermista's stomach and planting her into the mat. A finisher meant a great deal in getting you over, and Octavia was the sort of wrestler to put a lot of mustard on it in order to really sell it to the crowd. Maybe so her opponent didn't need to pretend?

Nevertheless, Mermista was sure that was it. Norwyn slid down for the three-count, Octavia covered her for the pin…

"One!"

"Kick out," Octavia whispered sluggishly.

"Two!"

Mermista blinked. What?

And kicked out with everything she had left.

"Thr—no, two! Two! That was two!" Norwyn stood back up, signalling the two-count to the timekeeper.

The crowd was on their feet, jumping, yelling, screaming. Octavia gathered Mermista up, both of them leaning on each other.

"Let's go home," Octavia whispered, panting. "Duck the line."

Going home only meant one thing in professional wrestling, and that was ending the match. It meant it was time to do the finish to the bout that they had agreed on backstage.

Except they hadn't agreed on anything. Octavia talked with Sea Hawk before the match, not Mermista. Mermista didn't know the finish, couldn't *do* the finish if she did (because you didn't steal your friend's moves) and *this was a title match*.

But she had just kicked out of Octavia's finisher. And Octavia was letting her fire back.

So, as Octavia Irish Whipped her into the ropes, Mermista ducked the clothesline, grabbed a hold of Octavia, muttered "pop-up drop" at the speed of light, and threw her into the ropes.

Octavia came bouncing back, arms outstretched. Mermista was ready. Octavia's hands fastened around shoulders, Mermista planted hers on Octavia's belly, and with a little jumping aid from Octavia, Mermista threw Octavia straight up into the air, caught her horizontally on her shoulders, and dropped backwards, driving Octavia into the middle of the ring.

"MERMISTA HITS OCTAVIA WITH A POP-UP SAMOAN DROP! This is it, DT! This has to be it!"

The noise from the crowd was relentless. Mermista glanced down at Octavia, caught her eye, and climbed the ropes. She rose up on

the third, spread her arms out, drank in the rising frenzy from the fans, and leapt.

“Mermista hits the Splash!”

Landing belly-first on Octavia drove all the air from her lung with a raspy cough. Still, she threw her arm out, climbing on top of Octavia and hauling her leg into the air. Norwyn sank down to the mat, beginning the count.

“ONE!”

Mermista’s head lolled around, a little bewildered. Octavia had her eyes closed. That meant…

“TWO!”

Mermista leaned a little closer, pretending to lock the pin in.

“Thank you,” she whispered, because that’s what you did.

“THREE!”

“No problem,” Octavia’s voice sounded below her, quiet, distant under the thunderous noise of Huntington Beach losing its god damn mind as Norwyn handed Mermista the Heavyweight belt and raised her hand into the air.

Mermista's theme music, Dick Dale’s *Misirlou* started playing over the speakers, a leftover relic from her god-awful surfer’s gimmick with which she had made her debut in EEW. Mermista didn’t care. The noise of the crowd was so, so much sweeter.

Tonight was her night.

“The winner of this match, and… NEW… EEW Heavyweight Champion… MERMISTA MASOE!”

Chapter End Notes

Chapter title is from the Smackdown program theme.

Pale Shadow of a Woman

Chapter Notes

Below follows a glossary for wrestling lingo that will appear in this chapter:

Kayfabe: The presentation of professional wrestling as being entirely legitimate or unscripted, and staying in-character.

Work: Anything planned to happen, or to 'deceive' an audience into believing what is happening on-screen to be real. Also used in saying someone is getting **worked**, meaning they are being fooled.

Promo: An in-character interview or speech done by wrestlers to move a storyline forward, generate interest or promote a match.

Valet: A person who accompanies wrestlers to the ring as a sidekick. Generally not involved in the actual match unless they interfere.

Book: A **booker** plans the matches. To be **booked** as something is to be written as that. **Booking** refers to the writing of storylines and match-ups.

Spot: A pre-planned action or sequence in a match.

Babyface: A wrestler who is generally considered 'good' or heroic in a wrestling match. Sometimes shortened to **face**.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Catra shoved the Hardcore belt into her duffle bag and zipped it shut, kicking open the backdoor and staggering her way outside.

The cold, fresh evening air hit her like a wrecking ball.

A wrecking ball to the stomach, because she immediately turned into a corner and noisily vomited the absence of a proper breakfast out onto the concrete. Leaning against the wall, riding out the convulsions of her stomach with burn marks on her arm, the phantom pain of glass stabbing into her back, wobbly legs and a score of individual hurts that the handful of Demerol painkillers just barely kept at a manageable level… Catra found the end of her night to be like any other one.

Her head was still stinging from Tung Lashor's chairshot. Maybe she should start putting her hands up…? But no, Lashor wasn't protecting himself, so why should she? Despite her gimmick, Catra was dead-set on being the last to pussy out of a proper spot.

"Need a ride?"

Catra turned around, pushing out a weary breath. In the dark, mostly deserted parking lot, she could only make out Adora's silhouette, leaning against an worn-out '76 Dodge Aspen.

Catra let her stare drift, to the distant bus stop, to the curb where Sweet Bee, Starla and Tallstar were climbing into a car, and sighed again.

She shambled over to Adora. She looked a great deal more presentable compared to Catra, who had thrown on Scorpia's windbreaker over her ring gear and left it at that, trying to ignore the way it chafed at her burnt arm. With some baggy jeans, the comfortable (if worn) red varsity jacket she had been wearing all her adult life and her hair done up in an easy ponytail, Adora was as much her polar opposite now as she had been inside the ring, wrestling her safe, inoffensive masturbatory tribute to the eighties, getting paid thrice as much as—

Catra took a deep breath.

“I don’t see a horde of screaming fans trailing behind you. What, you tell them to fuck off?”

Adora shrugged. “I had Micah put my gear on before he drove off. He’ll probably be taking them for a spin around the city.”

Catra leaned to the side, scanning the Dodge’s interior.

“And the others?”

Another shrug. “If I had to guess, bar crawling. Or the strip club.”

“You wanna join them?”

“…nah, not really. I mean, if you want to, I don’t mind—do you? Because…”

Catra shoved her duffle bag in Adora’s arms, finally finding a smile. “Let’s head to the airport. Nice and early.”

Adora beamed. “Let’s go.”

Catra made to walk around the hood when Adora stopped her in her tracks.

“Hold on—”

Dropping Catra’s duffle bag to the floor, Adora cupped Catra’s cheek with one hand, fishing out a handkerchief from her back pocket with the other.

“You have some, uh.”

Catra looked Adora in the eyes, unimpressed, as Adora gently dabbed something from her chin.

“…vomit. Sorry. It was really gross.”

“Ahuh.”

Adora folded the handkerchief up and stuffed it away. Catra hadn't moved, and neither had Adora's hand on her cheek.

The look in Adora's eyes reminded Catra of a softer time. A gentle time they knew had ended long ago, before they ever became wrestling superstars, even before they had given Weaver the finger and ditched her wrestling school, never to look back.

Before they had plunged headfirst into a decade of living on the road, sleeping at airports and cheap thirty dollar hotels. Putting their bodies on the line three nights a week, existing in a purgatory between ever-worsening pain and an ever-increasing toll of painkillers and steroids.

Drinking themselves silly those very same nights, because you had to keep up with the rest of the locker room or risk drawing the ire of a fucked-up self-destructive culture that pretended to be above the reality of a dog-eat-dog world. Resorting to doing cocaine before a match more and more, until they started taking it for promos and interviews too, just to maintain that intensity. Days off were spent high on acid or ecstacy instead, just to make up for the lost time that they knew they were never really getting back.

Fighting with each other. Arguing for three hours straight as they drove along the interstate, pretending like Adora's roid rage was something personally directed at Catra's self-perceived faults, pretending like Catra's reckless behaviour in the ring was done to get back at Adora tendency to worry for the one person in her life who meant *everything* to her.

Pretending like they didn't understand each other, when there was no one else in the world that truly did.

"How are you feeling?" Adora asked her quietly, pulling her gasping and kicking from her spiralling thoughts.

"Little sore," Catra admitted.

"Go sit down, okay? The seat's adjustable."

They released each other (Catra's hand had come to cover Adora's at some mysterious point), and Catra padded over to the shotgun side. She sank into the leather car seat, adjusting it all the way back. It was no bed, but it would do for now. She was already feeling her spine start to throb with that strangely sweet feeling of protest, as if it was straightening itself back out.

She probably couldn't count on a bed for at least another night and day, but that was alright. Sleeping on the plane would do.

It had to.

"I'm gonna need some serious ice," she muttered as Adora shut the door and started the engine.

"We can swing by the supermarket. I think there's a Safeway a few blocks ahead."

"Cool. I'm starving."

Catra turned the radio on as they pulled out of the lot and onto the streets of Huntington Beach. Van Halen's *Can't Stop Lovin' You* wasn't an unwelcome surprise.

"You wanna grab a meal?"

"Yeah…" Catra glanced aside, catching Adora's look. "What, dinner?"

"Totally!" Adora looked back ahead, drumming her fingers on the steering wheel. "We could hit up a diner, my treat."

"Mhmmm…" Catra sagged further into her seat, watching Adora through half-lidded eyes with a smirk. "Maybe a hotel, afterwards."

Adora laughed. "I'd love that. I'd love a *bed*. I'm dead tired."

"I could go for a little while longer."

“Yeah?” Adora leaned over, watching the road with half an eye. That low voice of hers as she added “and what did you have in mind?” was just *wonderful*.

“I’m picturing a whole lot…” Catra said teasingly.

It might be the leftover cocaine in her system or the warm numbness of taking too many painkillers or even the fact that her hand had unwittingly trailed up Adora’s thigh, but it seemed like she was working herself up a great deal more than Adora, who just laughed and sat back up straight.

“Ooh, something wicked, I bet.”

“Mh.”

“…like ditching tomorrow’s TV tapings.”

“Why not?” Catra challenged. “We could get a nice, chill hotel, hit the beach in the morning…”

“Cocktails in the afternoon…”

“Go sunbathing…”

“Catch a movie at the theatre?”

“*Fuck*,” Catra groaned dramatically. “When was the last time we did *that*?”

“Last year, I think. Unless you count that impromptu drive-in theatre Bow set up for the locker room in Toronto.”

“Sounds like a plan, honestly.”

“Two champions eloping the night after a pay-per-view? That’s the stuff of headlines.”

“If the journos still believed in kayfabe, maybe. Fuck them. It’s gonna be our day.”

Adora nodded, her smile soft and content. “It’s gonna be a good day.”

Catra tipped her head back. She didn’t need to watch the road to know that Adora wasn’t changing their course one bit, that they both silently knew they were just letting their imagination run wild. There was no missing the tapings, no matter what kind of strap you had around your waist. The gentler times were gone. The only reprieve in store for them were the quiet moments in-between.

Catra lifted her hand from Adora’s thigh, needily crabbing at her hand until Adora released the wheel and took Catra’s in her own.

The quiet moments they had with each other.

Mermista

“They’ll be alright,” Sea Hawk declared as they watched Catra and Adora drive off.

“Yeah,” Mermista sighed. “I guess.”

They were sitting together on the beach, watching the dark silhouettes of the waves lap against the shore. Mermista had her new belt in her lap, Sea Hawk his crutches. For whatever reason, he was dodging the medical personnel Hordak had set on him. For whatever reason, Mermista rolled with it.

It was far from a romantic scene. The sand was cold, a vaguely sticky kind of wet and absolutely littered with trash. In the distance and a little to the side, some college kids were screaming inanely as they dared each other to go skinny dipping.

"And so will you! In one fell swoop, you've secured the top title in our industry." Sea Hawk stroked his moustache, leaning back. "Octavia has been collecting paychecks for five pay-per-views in a row… she'll be grateful for her time off. When she's back, there's no doubt in my mind they'll write you two into a feud. In the meantime, Scorpia needs a new babyface to work with, Glimmer is looking for some performances… the world, I daresay, is your oyster."

Mermista nodded numbly through it all. Sea Hawk's animated chatter was actually pretty bearable right this second. In part because Mermista had come fresh off a title victory.

And also because, somewhere during their bout, Octavia had busted Mermista's ear so hard she ruptured her eardrum. Mermista was likely going to be deaf in that ear for the coming few weeks. It didn't ring or anything like that. It just gave off a numb hurt that blended in with the half-dozen other fresh bruises she had tallied up during the match.

"And you?" she asked quietly.

"Oh, I'll be fine. I thought, perhaps *I* could play the valet, while I'm working on this injury."

"Do you know how much it'll set you back?"

"Pfah, a meaningless detraction from the sum total of my worth. A visit, perhaps two, and they'll kick me out for excessively good health!"

"I can, like, help with the costs, you know. The Mad August pay-per-view is coming up, and Summerslam after that." She shrugged, hoping to mount some dismissiveness. "I guess I owe you."

"No need at all! I assure you, dearest, I have it completely under control." Sea Hawk flashed Mermista a look, and just like that she knew something was up. *Again*.

She squinted, glanced at his crutches, at his twitchy grin, at his legs.

She groaned.

"Oh my god you faked your fucking injury."

"I may have added a dramatic flair to the whole shebang…"

"You fucking worked us." Mermista stared at her feet, at the title in her lap. "You worked us all. You worked *Hordak*. He's gonna be *pissed* when he finds out…"

"Perhaps, or he'll be elated to know one of his TV workhorses is ready to return to the ring far sooner than he anticipated!"

But Mermista was putting the pieces together in her head. "You… booked me as your valet, *knowing* you were gonna work an injury…"

"All part of my brilliant secret plan…"

"And—what, you were *hoping* they'd let me take on Octavia? That Octavia would start goading me into the ring?"

"With some mild encouragement, indeed."

"That's why you and her went into the showers…" Mermista groaned. "You're crazy. You're *unhinged*. Why not *tell* me!?" She reached back, accentuating the word with a thump to his chest.

But there was no real venom behind it. Instead, she leaned into the punch, coming to rest against his shoulder.

"Why not tell me?"

Sea Hawk stretched, smoothly wrapping his arm around Mermista's shoulder. "Mh, I wanted it to be a surprise, or it would be a very *poor* secret plan…"

"That's, like, so dumb."

“Is that your assessment of my work?”

Mermista shifted her head to look up at Sea Hawk, still leaning against the security of his broad shoulder. She tried to think of something mildly scathing, to whittle away at that infuriatingly and handsomely triumphant smile of his.

“No, it was pretty rad,” she admitted, holding his eyes.

“That’s my girl.”

She decided the best way to both hide her blush and shut him up was to hook her finger around his bandana, and pull him in for a kiss.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter title is from Station to Station by David Bowie.

End Notes

Thank you for reading! It's my first time writing Seamista, so let me know what you think! And, since I realise not everyone might be familiar with the sport, I'll be happy to answer any questions or clear things up in the comments.

This was a little experimental. The life of professional wrestlers outside the ring is an entire subculture of its own, and I have no idea how well it will translate into writing. If you're wondering why everyone was far more aggressive and fired up than they would be in the canon show, the best way I can summarise it with the quote "An oldschool wrestling locker room is like high school, except everyone is the prom king, and everyone is on drugs." Outside of what you see on TV and in the ring, it's a very inglorious business.

Thank you to Døc, TrueBW3 and Eviebebeevie for beta-reading, thank you to Lisra and Lyssandia for help with the translations

Happy Pride, everyone ❤️

Work title is from Ashes to Ashes by David Bowie.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!